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Research Proposal

Research Title:
AI Algorithmic Bias and Public Trust: Why Readers Are Losing Faith in Digital News Platforms

IARCO - 2026

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1. Introduction

1.1 Background & Contextual Evolution

The public is losing confidence in journalism, consumption of news is changing and news portals are increasingly being used online, while AI-driven content recommendation increasingly target audiences [5]. The global digitalisation has transformed the channels through which information is transmitted, leading to a new level of speed, interactivity and multimedia interaction [1]. But the automatic, algorithmic selection of content in these platforms often raises significant concerns about opacity in content selection and deep ethical questions about the integrity of the information and an emerging trust issue in contemporary journalism [5].

1.2 Problem Statement

The digital news platform provides quick access to information, whereas an automated AI recommendation architecture has a powerful impact on content trustworthiness and user experience [5]. This study examines how the trust gap is growing between digital news readers and algorithmic bias in AI [5]. Also, sensationalized algorithmic results shape and diminish normal consumption patterns [5]. The study aims to tackle the pressing academic and practical concerns around the impacts of algorithmic bias and perceived manipulation on public trust, emphasising the need for algorithmic transparency in today's digital media landscapes [5].

2. Research Objectives

I. To comprehensively investigate how the trust gap is growing between digital news readers and algorithmic bias in AI.

II. To explore the deep implications of the opacity of AI content selection on institutional integrity and moral values of digital journalism.

III. Discuss the active effects sensationalized algorithmic results have on and diminish regular consumption.

IV. To develop algorithmic transparency-focused, evidence-based, strategic recommendations to restore trust and responsible AI usage in media.

3. Research Questions

RQ1: What is the growing disconnect between digitally consumed news and algorithmic bias of AI?

RQ2: How is the influence of the opacity of AI content selection on the credibility of digital journalism clear in specific ways?

RQ3: Does the sensationalized algorithmic results have an active effect on the regular readers behavior and lessen the normal consumption behavior?

4. Literature Review

This shift from traditional news outlets to AI-powered digital news platforms has revolutionized public discourse and information networks [1]. The vast body of research shows that AI-driven content suggestions are designed to appeal to the users' metrics, often pushing sensational or ideologically loaded material at the expense of an accurate and ethical presentation of information [2]. Algorithmic opacity is a condition that effectively encloses users in dubious “curation loops”, leaving audiences out of the digital platform and making them feel manipulated [3].

Moreover, in the modern times, the use of automated content curation is a notable change in the normal content consumption habits, causing readers to be skeptical and become digital fatigued [4]. Despite the general body of research on digital transformation, a gap exists in empirical studies that analyze the many actors involved in creating and implementing AI tools and their direct link to the public mistrust of the media in the region of South Asia [5]. Understanding these dynamics is important to gain background on the reception and vision of automated curation at different stages of production and consumption [5].

5. Methodology

5.1 Study Design

The design of this study is a rigorous multi-stakeholder qualitative research, in which nuanced perceptions from all kinds of digital media producers and consumers on automated content curation will be captured.

5.2 Data Collection Instruments

In order to collect rich, reliable and holistic qualitative data, a research framework is developed by combining two main data collection instruments, namely:

- **Key Informant Interviews (KIIs):** 12 KIIs with online news editors, technical experts of AI, media researchers and senior journalists.
- **In-Depth Interviews (IDIs):** 15 in-depth interviews with regular readers of news.5.3 Analytical Strategy

5.3 Analytical Strategy

These interviews are analysed using a detailed thematic and discourse analysis framework that explores the underlying drivers and implications of perceived AI manipulation on different levels of digital media production and consumption.

6. Expected Outcomes & Significance

- Explanation of the reasons behind the increasing mistrust of digital readers and AI systems.
- Empirical qualitative findings on the effect of unclear selection of AI produced content on journalistic credibility.
- A thorough understanding of the implications of sensationalized algorithmic results on the habits of the audience.

7. Novelty and Contribution

The multi-stakeholder qualitative approach in this study represents a valuable contribution to the debate on media ethics and responsible AI, connecting the various groups from the technical AI experts to news editors and from the technical experts to the consumers. The results provide concrete recommendations on the need for algorithmic transparency to regain public trust in digital platforms successfully.

8. Limitations & Scope

- The empirical scope is based on qualitative interviews with stakeholders and readers only; quantitative interviews with larger numbers could be of great value, and are recommended for the future.
- Geographic and demographic boundaries are largely focussed on specific digital news environments, and can be extended in subsequent wider studies.

9. Project Timeline

- **Month 1-2:** Literature review complete, KIIs and IDIs interview guide developed and reviewed, ethics preparation.
- **Month 3-4:** Conducting 12 Key Informant Interviews (KIIs) and 15 In-Depth Interviews (IDIs) with key informants to be interviewed.
- **Month 5–6:** Verbatim transcription, detailed thematic and discourse analysis of interview transcripts and qualitative coding of interview transcripts.
- **Month 7:** Core research findings are synthesized, contextual interpretations are drafted, and transparency recommendations are made.
- **Month 8:** Complete proofreading, formatting checks, and journal or conference submission.

10. Conclusion

In this research project, AI algorithmic bias and the growing public mistrust of digital journalism come together. The study employs a multi-stakeholder qualitative approach, based on expert key informant and reader in-depth interviews, to gain insight into how the opacity of content selection and sensationalized outputs of algorithms affect platform credibility and shape normal consumption practices. Overall, the results offer valuable theoretical and practical insights for advancing transparency and responsible AI ethics in today's digital news landscape.

11. References

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